THE DEVELOPMENT OF A THEOLOGY OF MISSION

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INTRODUCTION

Throughout the twentieth century, the evolution of missiology and mission action have a somewhat elastic, but traceable connection. Furthermore, each affected the other, as new theological and missiological perspectives pulled the mission activity in a particular direction, and as spurts of mission activity stimulated new missiological perspectives.

The multi-faceted world of mission and its players in 2000 is quite different than the world church which produced the conference of Edinburgh 1910. The century's Christian conferences and the documents proceeding from them can serve as historical markers to recognize and validate the existence of such change and divergent perspectives at a given point in time, and also to see how the various theological influences worldwide came together in action and reaction in new movements and new affiliations. Similarly, the progression of various issues considered at and concurrent with these conferences can serve as vehicles for recognizing the monumental shifts which occurred over the course of the century. Recognizing and evaluating these forces can help lend perspective toward a missiology and missional action of the next century, a theology which is still evolving today.

THE MAJOR SHIFTS THROUGHOUT THE CENTURY WITHIN THE ECUMENICAL MOVEMENT

Roger Bassham traced the historical development of mission theology beginning with Edinburgh 1910 and extending to 1975. He defined mission theology as "…those

theological presuppositions, statements, and principles which critically reflect upon and explicate God's purpose for the church in relation to the world" (Bassham 1979:7).

James Scherer and Stephen Bevans took up the description of new directions in mission and evangelization from 1974 to 1991 with a collection of statements on mission from Conciliar Ecumenical, Roman Catholic, Eastern Orthodox and Evangelical Protestant sources. Their *New Directions in Mission and Evangelization 2* reflects the theological foundations of mission from representatives of the one inclusively broad group of Christian sources. They observe, in exploring the theological foundations of mission, that "those foundations are not yet firmly in place. Today's missiological world is characterized by continuing change and abrupt transition…" (Scherer and Bevans 1992:xi, xiii).

At Edinburgh 1910, the conference developed a theological vision that laid the foundation for the ecumenical movement agenda with its broad concept of mission (Bassham 1979:15). Then, the Tambaram (Madras) meeting of 1938 provided continuity with the understanding of mission at Edinburgh 1910. It dealt with the relationship of the Christian message to the non-Christian world. "The question of the uniqueness of Christ was handled decisively. He was God's appointed savior intended for the whole world. There was no other Savior" (Hoekstra 1979:32). And, the 1947 Whitby meeting called for worldwide evangelism with continuity in the understanding of the meaning of mission from Edinburgh and Madras.

At Whitby, the IMC was commissioned to work with the WCC to conduct a survey of mission theology. This led to a project titled, "The Missionary Obligation of the Church," later modified to "The Calling of the Church to Mission and Unity." This document contained widely accepted perspectives on mission within the ecumenical movement but which had not been a articulated with such clarity before (Bassham 1979:31). The primary issue addressed was the tension between the inherent call to unity of the ecclesiastical body, in this case the WCC, as contrasted to the priority call of the mission structure, in this case the IMC to mission. The principles espoused were influential in shaping the future of the ecumenical movement.

> Missionary obligation and the movement towards unity … are "indissolubly connected." Each derives from obedience to God's work in Christ, and each intimately reflects to the other. A united church could give the best and clearest evangelical witness to the world, because mission and unity together comprise the meaning of "ecumenical" (Bassham 1979:32).

In the midst of the debate over connections between unity and mission, an important development in the theology of mission took place at the Conference at Willingen in 1952 when three important new perspectives of mission were brought to the foreground, the first of which was the Trinitarian basis of mission (Bassham 1979:49). The second emphasis was "…the notion of missio Dei," defined as follows: "…as God has sent his son to the world, so now he sends the church throughout the whole world to share in his mission" (Bassham 1979:167). These two changes were a promising start in

the development of the theology of mission in the period from 1948 to 1960 underscoring the Trinitarian basis and God-centeredness of mission. The third change in perspective of mission in the ecumenical stream, taking place from 1961 to 1975, was a shift in emphasis from the individual to society in regard to sin, salvation and mission. It was a secular theology of mission movement which was anti-church, anti-evangelism and shifted the emphasis onto the world.

The dividing line between two distinct foci in the theology of mission of the ecumenical movement is marked by the year 1961. The first change in understanding in the ecumenical mission was a change in sequence of the watchword from "God-Church-World" to "God-World-Church." From 1948 to 1961, the focus was on the church as the agent of God's mission in the world. From 1961 to 1975, emphasis was placed on the world as the locus for God's *missio,* in which the church participates by its witness in word and deed (Bassham 1979:166).

Another major change took place in 1961 at the Third General Assembly of the WCC in New Delhi. This conference shifted attention and resources away from mission and evangelism and moved them toward socio-political programs. It was a structural change within the ecumenical movement that occurred when the IMC integrated into the WCC as the Division of World Mission.

> The WCC promised that the missionary and evangelistic commitment would now become central to its life and work. The outcome, however, proved otherwise. Integration served at the outset to facilitate the new

> formulations about mission and later led to actual dismantling of missionary-sending capacity in most member churches. …What a large door would swing on that small hinge! (Hoekstra 1979:36)

Seven years later, at Uppsala '68, another shift in the theology of mission occurred. Historians noted a transitional break at 1945 designating the second half of the twentieth century as the post-war era. Some Christian historians point to a greater sharpness of discontinuity in the decade of the 1960s (Yates 1994:163). This decade was a time of upheaval in fundamental values and traditions, especially in the West. It was J.C. "Hans" Hoekendijk who connected with the students of the day with the missiologically radical view of a departure from the institutional church as primary agent of mission. He pointed "…to the missio Dei, God's activity in the world and its structures [functioning] independently of the church…" This was a very different understanding of the notion of missio Dei compared to what was conceived at Willingen[1] just eight years earlier (Bassham 1979:168). Catch phrases such as: "the world sets the agenda," "humanization," the church in the "function of apostolate" (the problem of the church in the framework of Kingdom-Gospel-Witness), and the "search for shalom" (God-given communal well-being) became part of the ecumenical terminology of mission in use at Uppsala '68 (Yates 1994:196-197). Hoekendijk's views infused the stream of changing

[1]Ecclesio-centric thinking actually started at Madras 1938; by 1952, Hoekendijk is on the attack. He wrote his dissertation on the German mission theory that ultimately was used by some to support the Nazi regime. Hoekendijk was highly incensed.

attitudes which converged at Uppsala and marked a significant radicalizing of the ecumenical concept (Yates 1994:164-165).

The evolution of the ecumenical concept of mission led to the reduction of the mission of the church to social and political activism, as Arthur Glasser observed at Uppsala '68, and as quoted by Hoekstra.

> Following the assembly at Uppsala great efforts were made to involve the WCC and its member churches more completely in the social struggle… Western capitalism and its institutions came under sharper and sharper attack. Injustices created by societal structures could not be adequately dealt with piecemeal. The only solution lay in a worldwide revolution in which the present capitalistic socio-economic-political institutions would be replaced. It would be a new world order in which ultimate power rested with the people (cited in Hoekstra 1979:111).

Dr. McGavran led the attack on the thrust of the proposals by writing an article that posited the rhetorical question, "Will Uppsala Betray the Two Billion?" (Bassham 1979:79) Despite efforts to the contrary the evangelical voice was not heard at Uppsala (Yates 1994:198). Nonetheless, by the late sixties, among evangelicals a movement was building to recover both the vertical and horizontal dimensions of the gospel. In the face of racism and poverty, it was recognized that a full-orbed gospel was required if evangelization was to be credible.

THE ROLE OF BIBLIOLOGY IN THE DISCUSSION OF MISSIOLOGY

Throughout the twentieth century the core theological issue was related to the inspiration, infallibility and interpretation of the Scriptures. The first sustained applause

in the opening address at Lausanne '74 given by Billy Graham revealed the importance to the participants when he said: "We are committed to the authority of Scripture; we hold the entire Bible is the infallible word of God" (Ford 1986:11). When John Stott presented the address on mission to Cambridge university students in 1975 which he had presented at Lausanne, reflects on the five key words of mission. Stott acknowledges the core question of a biblical hermeneutic in the opening remarks: "Perhaps the greatest need in current ecumenical debate is to find an agreed upon biblical hermeneutic, for without this a broader consensus on the meaning and obligation of 'mission' is unlikely ever to be reached (Stott 1975:10).

HUMANIZATION AS A MISSIOLOGICAL MOTIF AMONG ECUMENISTS

At Bangkok, in 1973, the term humanization became predominant as an interpretation of the mission of the church. The concept evolved into what became known as New Mission in Nairobi in 1975.

> By participating in this new Mission, the churches are joining with God in his mission of liberation. They are to work together with others from outside the churches as well as those from other churches in this common liberation struggle (Hoekstra 1979:124).

In a study based on interviews and observations made during his participation in 1975 in the WCC Fifth Assembly in Nairobi, Harvey Hoekstra, himself an active part of the ecumenical stream, noted:

> A definition of mission has emerged that many feel is too horizontal… primarily concerned to work for a better society… Such participation in the social struggle is a worthy objective as long as it does not lead to the eclipse or neglect of the churches' responsibility to win others to faith in Christ (Hoekstra 1979:10).

EVANGELICALISM EMERGES AS A REACTION TO TRENDS IN ECUMENICAL PERSPECTIVE

The integration debate of the International Missionary Council (IMC) with the WCC, which began about the time of Madras 1938, led to the demise of the IMC. This was an important stimulus to the emergence of the evangelical stream of conferences which began in 1960 and proliferated throughout the remainder of the century. "…[A]s early as 1947… Max Warren had prophesied that it was not 'right beyond the region of possibility that the fundamentalist churches and mission bodies may some time in the next few years try and [sic] constitute an international organisation of their own'" (Yates 1994:193). John R. Mott had expressed "grave reservations about a world body not motivated by missions, and fears that the World Council might swallow the International Missionary Council" (Hopkins 1979:689). Mott's fears were realized in 1961, as IMC did merge with the WCC at the New Delhi Assembly.

Some conferences were convened in a defensive mode to other conferences or streams. "The convening by evangelicals of the two Congresses on World Evangelization at Berlin in 1966 and at Lausanne in 1974 must unfortunately be understood, at least in part, as a loss of confidence in the World Council of Churches" (Stott 1982). David

Howard noted that the defensive posture towards the ecumenical movement came out repeatedly. He refers to Eugene Smith, a WCC observer at Wheaton 1966 who "…noted that nine of the fifteen major papers carried attacks on the ecumenical movement. Smith also stated that "…the distrust of the ecumenical movement within this group has to be experienced to be believed'" (Howard 1983:6).

The Lausanne '74 event admittedly sought to impact the next WCC general assembly as stated in the opening remarks of the event by honorary chairman, Billy Graham, who stated that he would like to see the Congress frame a biblical declaration of evangelism to speak "…with a strong clear voice, one which would challenge the next World Council of Churches Assembly" (Ford 1986:13).

One of the more surprising concepts borrowed from the ecumenical stream by the evangelical stream is the paradigm used for the Lausanne Movement, "[World Evangelization requires the] whole church taking the whole Gospel to the whole world." This comes directly from paragraph six of the Lausanne Covenant. At the Consultation on the Relationship between Evangelism and Social Responsibility co-sponsored by the LCWE and WEF in 1982 there was a whole-hearted acceptance of this statement. However, it was borrowed from the ecumenical stream. In fact, it was built into the understanding of the essence of what the WCC called ecumenical. "The word ecumenical is properly used to describe everything that related to the whole task of the whole Church

to bring the Gospel to the whole world"[2] (Hogg 1952:11). The concept could be traced from earlier reflections in conferences such as the IMC gathering in Madras in 1938, which included among their recommendations the following: "The responsibility for evangelism was the task of the whole Church for the whole world" (Bassham 1979:24). Then at the first assembly of the WCC at Amsterdam in 1948 is "…the whole Church should set itself to the total task of winning the whole world to Christ" (Bassham 1979:29).

UNIFYING PRINCIPLES AMONG EVANGELICALS

International Foreign Mission Association (IFMA) '60 marked a beginning of the efforts of evangelicals to seek a well-defined identity. IFMA was an association of independent North American faith missions. They adopted a theologically conservative stance which placed them outside of the WCC and the ecumenical movement (Bassham 1979:173). The emphasis of mission at IFMA '60 was obedience to the Great Commission. With the founding of Fuller Theological Seminary's School of World Mission in 1965, church growth became the test of mission and the church growth movement became the most "persuasive and extensive evangelical contribution to mission theology" (Bassham 1979:188, 198).

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[2] From *The World Council of Churches: Minutes and Reports of the Fourth Meeting of the Central Committee*. Rolle, Switzerland, August 4-11, 1951:65. (cited in Hogg 1957:11).

Church Planting

At Wheaton '66 it was affirmed once again: "…church planting has the priority among all other missionary activities" (Bassham 1979:211). During Wheaton '66, long-time North American evangelical leader Clyde Taylor explained the change of the emphasis in the development of the divinely appointed task for the church by the changing of the term missions to mission.

> Moreover, this "mission" includes all united Protestant bodies functioning in their total impact on world society. This involves the Church in economic, social, legislative, administrative, education of youth, welfare, and religious matters. Hence, it can well be said that the mission of the church is not only to get the "uncommitted" in the Church "committed," but its business includes every possible impact that the Church can have in and upon society" (Lindsell 1966:143).

Authority of Scripture

Berlin '66 articulated a theology of mission in an effort to establish the identity and theological perspective of the Congress:

> In contrast to other recent ecumenical conferences, such as the Vatican Council, World Council of Churches, assemblies, and the conferences on Faith and Order, and on Church and Society, [this Congress] assumes both the Reformation principle of the final authority of the Bible and the apostolic emphasis on the evangelization of mankind as the primary mission of the church (Bassham 1979:221).

For the first time since World War I, there entered a sense of optimism at Berlin '66 in regard to the completion of the task of world evangelism. "Billy Graham has challenged Christendom to think about World Evangelism in terms of 10 years, rather

than ‘in our generation.’ This is an attainable goal if Christian leaders are willing to harness the vast potential of Literature Evangelism” (Henry and Mooneyham 1967:514). Berlin ‘66 defined evangelicalism as a prioritization of the spiritual transformation of individuals over the political restructuring of society.

World Evangelization

Lausanne ’74 took up the task of world evangelization and described this as an agenda which incorporated all of the concerns embraced by the word Mission (Bassham 1979:231). Lausanne produced a notable shift in evangelical mission theology. “This occurred through broadening the focus of the Congress from evangelism to mission—a move in which Stott played a decisive role” (Bassham 1979:231). And “…Stott and others in the evangelical world had moved in their understanding of the Great Commission, which, on Stott’s own account, at Berlin ‘66 had been strictly in terms of evangelism” (Yates 1994:208). The Lausanne Covenant brought together the major streams within evangelicalism and even the more theologically conservative periphery of the liberalizing ecumenical movement. For all intents and purposes it consolidated a theological and missiological consensus (Yates 1994:203).

THE NATURE OF EVANGELISM

Perhaps the most debated issue in the twentieth century conference dialogue across all streams was that of the social implications of the gospel. The debate not only

took place between the ecumenical and the evangelical streams of Protestantism but also within the ecumenical and evangelical streams.

Within the ecumenical stream the International Missionary Council (IMC) Jerusalem 1928 conference paid special attention to the relationship between evangelism and social action. An extensive study of social problems was made as it related to missionary work. Issues such as discrimination between human beings were openly debated. "The search for wholeness in mission was evident…" (Bassham 1979:21). At the birth of the World Council of Churches (WCC) in 1948, representatives from the six continents discussed the most pressing issues at hand. "The discussion reflected the growing uncertainty about the whole matter of evangelism" (Fey 1970:178). The emphasis within the ecumenical stream on the social implications of the gospel steadily grew with each passing conference until evangelism is eclipsed completely at the fifth general assembly of the WCC in Nairobi in 1975.

> There was no call to evangelism, no recognition that existing efforts of churches are inadequate to evangelize the multitudes yet unreached. The focus was on participation in struggle against injustice. The vision was of a new *oikumene* where people peoples of different religions and cultures learn to live and work together in a new community where all participate in determining the common good (Hoekstra 1979:126).

Reacting to the ecumenical views, the organizers of Wheaton '66 expressed their deep concern that the WCC had moved from "…direct evangelism toward greater

emphasis upon the greater social and economic structures instead of personal regeneration…" (Lindsell 1966:3).

Berlin '66 reaffirmed the primacy of evangelism. But the relationship between evangelism and social concern was addressed by Carl Henry:

> But the Gospel of Jesus Christ ... upholds the dignity of man by offering a recovery of his squandered destiny through the forgiveness of sins and a new life. The God of the Bible is the God of justice and of justification. The Christian evangelist has a message doubly relevant to the modern scene: he knows that justice is due to all because a just God created mankind in his holy image, and he knows that all men need justification because the Holy Creator sees us as rebellious sinners. The Gospel is good news not simply because it reinforces modern man's lost sense of personal worth and confirms the demand for universal justice on the basis of creation, but also because it offers rebellious men as doomed sinners that justification and redemption without which no man can see God (Howard 1983:9-10).

In his opening remarks at Lausanne '74, Billy Graham indicated that he hoped that "Lausanne could point out the relationship between evangelism and social responsibility." He expected the Congress to reaffirm that "…our witness must be by both word and deed. You cannot separate the two" (cited in Ford 1986:13). One of the developments of Lausanne '74 was the broadening of the meaning of the term mission. This was articulated especially by John R. W. Stott in his paper on "The Biblical Basis of Evangelism." Stott remarked that his position had changed since Berlin '66 in that he

now understood the Great Commission to include social as well as evangelistic responsibility[3].

Stott was influenced in his thinking by a group of Latin Americans, led by Orlando Costas, including Rene Padilla and Samuel Escobar, to affirm at Lausanne '74 the conviction that evangelism and social action are inextricably linked. They succeeded in having this affirmation included in the Lausanne Covenant as Article 5 (Thomas 1998:315).

It was Costas who pioneered the concept of holistic evangelism. Behind this work about an evangelism that is Good News for both the sinner and the sufferer is an evangelist who embodied the integrity of mission. His commitment was radical word and radical deed. Costas' view serves as a "bridge" theological mission perspective somewhere in between the WCC and LCWE main streams. He rightly concludes that the

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[3] David Howard develops the changing perspective as articulated by John Stott who was called the theologian-in-residence at Lausanne '74. Stott stated: "Recently **...** the word 'mission' has come to be used in a wider and more general sense, to include evangelism but not to be identical with it, and I see no reason why we should resist this development. 'Mission' is an activity of God arising out of the very nature of God. The living God of the Bible is a sending God, which is what 'mission' means." Stott goes on to define mission in terms of service, including, but not limited to evangelism. He ties together the Great Commandment with the Great Commission. "The Great Commission neither explains, nor exhausts, nor supersedes the Great Commandment. What it does is to add to the command of neighbor—love and neighbor—service a new and urgent Christian dimension. If we truly love our neighbor we shall without doubt tell him the Good News of Jesus. But equally if we truly love our neighbor we shall not stop there." Stott later expanded this paper in book form, where he stated his own progression in thinking since Berlin '66. Referring to previously held interpretations of the Great Commission as being exclusively related to "preaching, converting, and teaching," he says, "Indeed, I confess that I myself argued this at the World Congress on Evangelism in Berlin in 1966, when attempting to expound the three major versions of the Great Commission. "Today, however, I would express myself differently **...** I now see more clearly that not only the consequences of the commission, but the actual commission itself must be understood to include

hermeneutical perspective becomes the hinge point of debate. His reflections on the 1980 conferences at Melbourne, sponsored by the WCC, and Pattaya '80, sponsored by the LCWE, illustrate his own bias. In appealing to a primarily social rather than linguistic view of mankind he naturally embraces the need for temporal liberation, the issue of injustice and the prophetic themes of mission over the need for eternal liberation, the issue of spiritual lostness, and the proclamation theme of mission (Costas 1982:154). As a speaker at Wheaton '83, Costas continued to emphasize the importance of a holistic strategy in the context of the emergence of third-world missions. He argued that "the complexity of our world, the comprehensive character of the Christian world mission and the diversities of third world missions, point to the need of a holistic strategy" (Costas cited in Fraser 1983:227).

The debate within the evangelical stream regarding the nature of evangelism came to a head at Pattaya '80. While the event illustrated the debate between the ecumenical and evangelical stream (See Table 1), it also highlighted the debate within the streams. During the conference a statement of concerns was circulated challenging the conference leadership to the fact that Pattaya '80 had retreated from the Lausanne position stated in paragraph 5 of the Lausanne '74 Covenant that affirmed that "the message of salvation implies also a message of judgment upon every form of alienation, oppression and

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social as well as evangelistic responsibility, unless we are to be guilty of distorting the words of Jesus" (Stott cited in Howard 1983).

discrimination and we should not be afraid to denounce evil and injustice wherever they exist." David Bosch describes this shift in paradigm as follows:

> We thus have two almost entirely contradictory understandings of evangelism. Some (not all) ecumenicals would define it almost exclusively as Christian sociopolitical involvement; some (not all) evangelicals would define it as calling people to a lifestyle where only personal and individual conduct matters (Bosch 1981:67).

Bosch further expresses his view regarding what he calls "…the typical shortcomings in the evangelical understanding of evangelism in the section titled Shades of Dualism in a chapter titled, "An Emaciated Gospel." He presents the view that the evangelicals truncate the gospel, supporting his argument from the documents produced at major conferences. The linkage of service to witness addressed in the course of the conferences became a point of reference in the ongoing debate.

> Efforts have recently been made to link witness and service more closely. Frequently, however, there has been little success, with the result that service remains a secondary element. Both the Wheaton Declaration (1966) and the Lausanne Covenant (1974) reveal this. The problem is that the solution is usually found in that the social dimension and the believer's involvement in the world are added on to evangelism (Bosch 1980:204).

The consultation on the relationship between evangelism and social responsibility held in Grand Rapids, Michigan, in 1982 was an effort to address the potentially divisive issue raised at Pattaya '80 within the evangelical stream. The eight major papers and responses included in the book titled *In Word And Deed: Evangelism and Social Responsibility* reflect that there are still diverse perspectives on the issue Nicholls 1985). At Grand Rapids, the primacy of evangelism continued to be emphasized yet, at the same

time, there was new clarification of what evangelism means. In the concluding remarks of the final presentation on the mission of the church, Choongnahm Cho emphasized the importance of maintaining the primacy of evangelism since "the root of the problem in our society lies in the selfish sinful hearts of man" (Nicholls 1985:234). As chairman for the drafting committee of the influential document ensuing from the consultation, Stott clarified the meaning of evangelism and its primacy. Thus, evangelism and social responsibility, while distinct from one another, are integrally related in our proclamation of and obedience to the Gospel. The partnership is, in reality, a marriage… This brings us to the question whether the partnership between evangelism and social responsibility is equal or unequal, that is, whether they are of identical importance or whether one takes precedence over the other. …First, evangelism has a certain priority. We are not referring to an invariable temporal priority, because in some situations a social ministry will take precedence, but to a logical one. …Secondly, evangelism relates to people's eternal destiny, and in bringing them Good News of salvation, Christians are doing what nobody else can do (Stott 1982).

Wheaton '83 provided a platform for further clarification of the response to human need among evangelicals. In the book containing the presentations made at the "Consultation on the Church in Response to Human Need," edited by the co-presenters of the topic "Evangelism and Social Responsibility" a year earlier, Vinay Samuel and Chris

Sugden, the final document titled "Transformation" reflects, by its very name, the call for societal transformation (Samuel and Sugden 1987:254-265).

THE RESURFACING TENSION BETWEEN EVANGELISM AND SOCIAL CONCERN

The debate regarding the place of social concern within the mission mandate continued both within the evangelical and ecumenical streams and between them.

Tension Within the Evangelical Stream

Despite the efforts of the so-called radical discipleship group at Lausanne, Bosch discerned the division between evangelism and social concern which he called a two-mandate approach and which resurfaced as a fatal dichotomy, as he put it, at Pattaya '80 (Bosch 1991:405-408). The concern was considered legitimate by the evangelical stream represented by Lausanne, leading to a consultation in Bermuda in 1978 on the Gospel and Culture. At Bermuda '78 there was the acknowledgement for a mission of holism and that "no theological statement is culture free" (Yates 1994:209).

Tension Between the Evangelical and Ecumenical Stream

Pattaya '80 accepted the framework of Christian mission as interpreted in the Lausanne Covenant and was convened "to seek a fresh vision and power for the task Christ has given to his church until he comes" (Howard 1983:20).

Two global events held in 1980 reflected the different understanding of mission within Protestantism as shown in Table 1. The ecumenical WCC-sponsored Melbourne event and the evangelical Lausanne-sponsored Pattaya event, though only one month apart, promoted two very different understandings of mission.

> But then leaders of the World Council have also been justly critical of many of us evangelicals for our lack of social concern. This polarisation became particularly visible in 1980 when the conference Your Kingdom Come (sponsored by the WCC's Commission on World Mission and Evangelism) was held in Melbourne in May, and the following month the consultation How Shall They Hear? (sponsored by the Lausanne Committee) took place at Pattaya, Thailand. Neither group had intended that these meetings should be juxtaposed in this way, although perhaps it served to highlight the continuing tension. A number of evangelicals attended both conferences and found reasons for hope in both. For a perusal of the documents makes it plain that there was much common ground between them. Nevertheless, the emphasis was different. At Melbourne the necessity of proclamation was clearly recognized, but the cries of the poor, the hungry and the oppressed predominated. At Pattaya also the cries of the needy were heard (one mini-consultation focused on refugees, and another on the urban poor), but the call to proclaim the gospel to the unevangelized predominated (Stott 1982).

TABLE 1

COMPARISON OF THE ECUMENICAL AND EVANGELICAL UNDERSTANDING OF MISSION
(Adapted from Bosch 1981:65-66)

Melbourne	Pattaya
1. Showed a preference for "Jesus language" of the Gospels.	1. Showed a preference for the language of Paul's epistles.
2. Began with "human's disorder."	2. Began with "God's design."
3. Stressed unity (at the expense of truth?).	3. Stressed truth (at the expense of unity?).
4. Believe that God reveals himself also through contemporary experience.	4. Believe that God reveals himself only through Jesus Christ (and in scripture/the
5. Emphasized the deed (orthopraxis)	5. Emphasized the word (orthodoxy).
6. Regarded social involvement as part and parcel (or all?) of the Christian mission.	6. Regarded social involvement as separate from mission, or as a result of conversion.
7. Judged societal ethics to be of prime importance Viewed sin as having a corporate dimension.	7. Judged personal ethics to be of prime importance. Viewed sin as exclusively personal.
8. Tended to equate mission with humanization or social change.	8. Tended to equate mission with a call to conversion or church planting.
9. Viewed proclamation as rendering support to fellowship and service.	9. Viewed proclamation as primary; it gives birth to fellowship and service.
10. Emphasized liberation.	10. Emphasized justification and redemption.
11. Heard the cry of the poor and the oppressed.	11. Heard the cry of the lost.
12. Considered humans from the perspective of Creation.	12. Considered humans from the perspective of the Fall.
13. Judged humanity positively.	13. Judged humanity negatively.
14. Denied the existence of clear boundaries between the church and the world.	14. Affirmed the existence of clear boundaries between the church and the world.
15. Regarded the world as the main arena of God's activity.	15 Regarded the church as the main arena of God's activity.
16. Underscored the church's credibility.	16. Underscored the church's opportunities
17. Divided the world into rich and poor, oppressor and oppressed.	17. Divided the world into "people groups."
18. Revealed a proclivity towards socialism.	18. Revealed a proclivity towards capitalism.
19. Highlighted Jesus' human nature.	19. Highlighted Jesus' divine nature.
20. Focused attention on the universality of Christ.	20. Focused attention on the uniqueness of Christ.

THE ELUSIVE QUEST FOR A COMPREHENSIVE DEFINITION OF MISSION

After reviewing perspectives on missiology from the various Christian streams in *New Directions 2*, James Scherer, one of the editors of the collection of theological perspectives on mission, pursues an agreed-on understanding of what mission is. He establishes the need for a definition of missiology because of the "…current indecision, or at least a divergence of opinion, about what mission fundamentally is" (Scherer and Bevans 1992:175). In his concluding thoughts on the elusive quest for a definition of mission, he admits that it remains obscure: "Missiology, reflecting the status of mission itself, is in a state of flux and ferment. No single definition of 'what missiology is' will satisfy all stripes of missiologist in the absence of prior agreement on 'what mission is'" (Scherer and Bevans 1992:175). The quest for understanding mission and missiology continues.

One group that has responded to the challenge of the search for the meaning of mission is the American Society of Missiology which has come up with a definition helpful for its clarity and brevity. "By mission is meant the effort to effect passage over the boundary between faith in Jesus Christ and its absence" (Shenk 1999:xi). A helpful concept in the pursuit of a meaning for mission is the realization that "[m]ission is synonymous with movement. It stands for purposeful going and doing. Mission implies challenge to the status quo and invites change" (Shenk 1999:1). In pursuing the path for

the future of the conceptualization of mission as movement Wilbert Shenk explores the changing frontiers of mission. Several observations from his reflection help to set the stage for the next phase of the mission enterprise.

> 1. The modern missionary movement …has ended, and a new epoch in Christian mission is unfolding. 2. Christian faith is inherently expansionist: this expansionist impulse is linked to the goal of history. 3. Renewal of faith will be linked to the recovery of a vision of Jesus Christ as God incarnate who became savior and lord; genuine renewal will issue in fresh missionary witness. 4. Faithful mission is always in vital relationship with the sociopolitical realm. 5. The church of the future will be a minority church in many parts of the world. 6. In every age the church must struggle to remain open to the fullness of the gospel. 7. The Word is the singular seminal force. 8. The greatest integrity and vitality of faith today appears to be found in those churches that have suffered and known martyrdom firsthand (Shenk 1999:186-190).

In seeking to determine a statement of mission which encompassed the vision of all the major players, it was soon evident that there no longer existed any "least common denominator" which would satisfy the groups. The bodies had moved too far apart with too much stratification in the thinking of each group since the days of Edinburgh.

CONCLUSION

The seeds of change in the face of world Christian theology were sown early in the century by such committed evangelicals such as John Mott, who was able to hold the two ideas of social action and evangelism in tension, without diluting either. This was not achieved, however, by those that followed, and differing points of view regarding foundational issues such as view of scriptures and interpretation of the primacy of social

action versus spiritual transformation eventually bore fruit in the form of differing missional actions, one focusing on "liberating" social conditions and the other focusing on individual spiritual transformation. Eventually the lack of significant unifying and energizing concepts among the ecumenical wing led to a decline in missional activity, until the ecumenical movement ceased to "move" at all, except perhaps on paper.

While the focus on unity held by Mott and others was entirely biblical and commendable according to John 17, it was the *exclusive* focus on unity as the mission of the church which unfortunately had the opposite effect, leaving behind the evangelical branch of the church, who had other concerns no longer shared by the ecumenists. This divergence eventually transferred the major unifying energy into the camp of those who did not seek it except as means to an end, just as did Mott.

Missiologists of the new century will do well to bear in mind the lessons of the previous century regarding promoting concepts which actually bring unity, (unity itself not being among them), and seek to emulate Mott, who succeeding in holding out the whole counsel of scripture without pitting biblical concepts one against each other, or letting one run away untethered from the other. Such creative tension will enliven the whole Church to exercise a full panoply of gifting, address the world's various areas of need for the Church's ministry to it, and perhaps begin to reflect a more complete revelation of Jesus Christ who charged the church to go in His name.

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